cessation of all assistance if India tested again. Large countries like Brazil and Russia sat on the sidelines. Japan remained silent although it had assured India that it would not oppose a consensus. China went public by asking that there should not be a single exception, but a criterion or rules-based decision applicable to all non-NPT signatories.

They deemed this to be a principle, which is another classic Chinese diplomatic ruse. This was a calculated Chinese attempt to include Pakistan in the exception. On 21–22 August 2008, the Group of Six tabled a series of 'killer' amendments to the American text, including a provision to terminate nuclear trade with India if it carried out further nuclear tests, that the waiver given to India should exclude Enrichment and Reprocessing Technologies, and a demand for a periodic review of India's compliance. These were designed to make the waiver 'conditional'. China lent quiet support. It also put up its own minor amendments with the intention of delaying the process. These amendments were contrary to India's wish for a clean waiver. Eventually, talks in Vienna in August 2008 ended in a deadlock. China assumed that the wall of opposition to making an exception for India was unbreachable.

This confidence was reflected, perhaps for the first time, in the Chinese official mouthpiece, the *People's Daily*, on 2 September 2008. It confidently declared that 'The Safeguards Agreement between the IAEA and India is a very loose non-binding agreement. It is neither clarified what kind of nuclear facilities should fall under IAEA supervision, nor stipulates if all civil nuclear facilities and fuel should be under permanent IAEA supervision. This has aroused concerns—is India enjoying the same rights as NPT Members without corresponding obligations?' [23] Here lay the heart of the Chinese argument, and thinking that there was sizeable opposition within the NSG, the Chinese felt confident enough to join the chorus, publicly.